Gustavo Acosta

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics
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Research Fields

Primary: Development Economics, Labor Economics; **Secondary**: Behavioral and Experimental Economics, Health Economics.

EDUCATION

University of Michigan — Ph.D. Candidate in Economics 2023–Present
University of Michigan — M.A. in Economics (Pathway to Ph.D.) 2025
Pontifical Catholic University of Peru (PUCP) — B.A. in Economics (Summa Cum Laude) 2013–2018
Australian National University — Exchange Student, Economics Master's Program (Australian Government-funded) 2017

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

University of Michigan 2024–2025
Research Assistant
- Supervisor: Emma Riley. Project on adolescent girls' economic and social empowerment in Tanzania (2025).
- Supervisor: Elisa Maffioli. Projects on malaria vaccines and fake drugs in Africa (2024–2025).

Duke University 2020–2023
Pre-Doctoral Research Fellow
- Supervisors: Erica Field, Robert Garlick, and Katherine Vyborny. Projects in Peru and Pakistan on health, gender, labor markets, and survey methodology.

Innovations for Poverty Action 2018–2020
Senior Research Associate
- Peru. Supervisors: Erica Field, Livia Schubiger, and Javier Romero. Projects on health and gender-based violence.
- Paraguay. Supervisor: Nathan Fiala. Projects on poverty and financial inclusion.

WORKING PAPERS (IN ORDER OF COMPLETENESS)

- *Text Messaging for Mental Health Management During the COVID-19 Pandemic.*[*2] With Erica Field, Daniel Hurtado, and Javier Romero.
- *Imprecise Beliefs About Malaria Infection Risk and Vaccine Protection in Ghana* (Third-Year Paper).
- *The Political Economy of University Licensing: Evidence from Peru's Higher Education Reform.*[*2] With Leah Lakdawala, Fabiola Alba, and Diego Mestanza.
- *Human Capital Investment under Immigration Policy: Evidence from STEM OPT.*[*1] With Marcia Ruiz.
- *The Price of Safety: The Effect of Organized-Crime Extortion on Microfirm Outcomes.*[*1] With Gabby Lecaro.
- *Are Insiders or Community Leaders Effective in Identifying Intimate Partner Violence?*[*3] With Erica Field.

** Drafts available upon request.*

SELECTED WORK IN PROGRESS

- *Measuring and Addressing Gender-Based Harassment in Public Spaces: Experimental Evidence from Developing Cities.*[*1] With Marcia Ruiz. Pilot completed, with data collection scheduled for 2026. (AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0019317)
- *From Gendered Spheres to Shared Responsibility: An Experiment on the Maintenance of Household Capital in Peru.*[*1] With Marcia Ruiz. Midline completed, with data collection scheduled for 2026. (AEA RCT Registry: AEARCTR-0019332)
- *Keeping the Commons Clean: Experimental Evidence on Prosocial Motivation, Coordination, and Monitoring in Uganda.*[*1] With Marcia Ruiz and Laston Manja. Pilot completed, with data collection scheduled for 2026.
- *Extortion and Firm Decisions in Peru: Measurement, Field Experiments, and a Dynamic Model.*[*1] With Gabby Lecaro. Pilot completed, with data collection scheduled for 2026.
- *Targeted School Benefits and Student Sorting: Evidence from Peru.*[*1] With Muchin Bazan and Maria Ferro.
- *Targeting Men to Reduce Domestic Violence: An Evaluation of Men for Equality.*[*3] With Erica Field. Baseline completed, with endline data collection scheduled for 2026.
- *Providing Real-Time, Accurate Data to Increase Malaria Vaccine Completion Rates in Ghana.*[*3] With Jessica Cohen and Elisa Maffioli. Baseline completed.

*[*1] Coauthored with peer graduate students. [*2] Coauthored with faculty and peer graduate students. [*3] Coauthored with faculty.*

PRE-PH.D. PUBLICATIONS (INCLUDING SUBMISSIONS)

- Acosta, G., P. Francke, and D. Quispe. 2026. "Effects of Peru's National School Feeding Program (Qali Warma) on Overweight and Obesity Among Children Aged 36–59 Months." *Obesities*, 6(3), 25.
- Acosta, G. and P. Francke. 2021. "Impact of the Qali Warma School Feeding Program on Chronic Child Malnutrition." *Apuntes*.
- Acosta, G. and P. Francke. 2020. "Impact of Micronutrients 'Sprinkles' on Chronic Childhood Malnutrition in Peru." *Revista Médica Herediana*.

POLICY NOTES & MEDIA

- Acosta, G., E. Field, H. Khan, and K. Vyborny. 2023. *Lockdowns and Learning Outcomes: Insights from 10th Grade Examination Results in Pakistan*. PEDL C-19 Note.
- "SVRI Research Grant Partners 2026." Video presentation, Sexual Violence Research Initiative, 2026.

SELECTED RESEARCH GRANTS

Secured USD 275,375 across projects led independently or with graduate-student collaborators.
Secured USD 1,784,375 across all projects, including collaborations with faculty.

- **Measuring and Addressing Gender-Based Harassment in Public Spaces: Experimental Evidence from Developing Cities (USD 132,500).** Sexual Violence Research Initiative — USD 100,000 (2026); Weiss Fund — USD 25,000 (2025); U-M PACLSHR Grant — USD 6,000 (2025); Rackham Research Grant — USD 1,500 (2025). **Lead PI, with Marcia Ruiz.**
- **From Gendered Spheres to Shared Responsibility: An Experiment on the Maintenance of Household Capital in Peru (USD 48,375).** Peruvian Government Housing Grant — USD 28,375 equivalent (PEN 97,240; 2026); SYLFF Research Grant — USD 10,000 (2025); Marshall Weinberg Fellowship — USD 8,500 (2025); Rackham Research Grant — USD 1,500 (2025). **MPI, with Marcia Ruiz.**
- **Keeping the Commons Clean: Experimental Evidence on Prosocial Motivation, Coordination, and Monitoring in Uganda (USD 68,500).** Marshall Weinberg Fellowship — USD 8,500 (2026); U-M African Studies Center — USD 3,000 (2026); PSC Small Grant in Population Research — USD 28,500 (2026); IGC Research Grant — USD 28,500 (2025). **MPI, with Marcia Ruiz and Laston Manja.**
- **Extortion and Firm Decisions in Peru: Measurement, Field Experiments, and a Dynamic Model (USD 14,000).** SYLFF Research Grant — USD 10,000 (2026); U-M Economics Research Grant — USD 2,500 (2026); Rackham Research Grant — USD 1,500 (2025). **MPI, with Gabby Lecaro.**
- **Targeting Men to Reduce Domestic Violence (USD 90,000).** Government of Peru Grant via IPA Peru — USD 90,000 (2026). **MPI, with Erica Field.**
- **Ghana Malaria Vaccine Adherence RCT (USD 1,419,000).** Global Development Incubator — USD 1,220,000 (2025); Weiss Fund — USD 199,000 (2025). **Co-Investigator, with Jessica Cohen and Elisa Maffioli.**
- **Public Health and Social Programs in Peru: Machine Learning and Impact Evaluation (USD 12,000).** Economic and Social Research Consortium (CIES/USAID) — USD 5,000 (2020); National Institute of Statistics and Informatics (INEI) — USD 7,000 (2019). **MPI, with Pedro Francke.**

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

- **2026:** Scholars Program Fellowship and Travel Grant, National Association for Business Economics (NABE) — 2026–27 cohort, USD 400; Fellowship and Travel Grant, Michigan Center for Infectious Disease Threats — USD 1,750; Graduate Travel Award, University of Michigan Department of Economics — USD 1,400; Graduate Travel Award, Rackham Graduate School — USD 1,200.
- **2018:** Best B.A. Thesis Award, PUCP Department of Economics.
- **2017:** Australian Government Program Scholarship, Australian National University — AUD 5,000.

SELECTED INVITED SEMINARS AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS (INCLUDING SCHEDULED)

- **2027:** AEA/ASSA Annual Meeting (Washington, DC).
- **2026:** 4th Annual Midwest Experimental Economics Meeting for Graduate Students (Michigan); Southern Economic Association 96th Annual Meeting (Texas); LACEA-LAMES 2026 Annual Meeting (Peru); 10th Annual NABE Tech Economics Conference & Industry Job Fair (California); 68th NABE Annual Meeting (Ohio); Arnold Ventures BRIDGE Event on Public Safety Challenges for Agencies (Ohio); SVRI Grantee Workshop (Virtual); Financial Literacy Research Boot Camp (California); 21st Australasian Development Economics Workshop (Australia); RIDGE Summer School (Barbados); Arnold Ventures BRIDGE Event on Online Harassment and Stalking (Washington, DC); Midwest Economics Association 90th Annual Meeting (Illinois).
- **2025:** University of Ghana School of Public Health Seminar (Ghana).

CURRENT COLLABORATIONS

- **Peru:** Ministry of Women and Vulnerable Populations (2018–Present); Ministry of Housing, Construction, and Sanitation (2024–Present); Ministry of Transport and Communications (2025–Present); AJE Group, a Peruvian multinational beverage company (2025–Present).
- **Ghana:** Ghana Health Services (2025–Present).
- **Uganda:** Ministry of Lands, Housing and Urban Development (2025–Present); Ministry of Health (2026–Present); Kampala Capital City Authority (2025–Present).
- **Colombia:** Banca de las Oportunidades (2026–Present).
- **USA:** Pirth.org (2026–Present).

TEACHING EXPERIENCE AND DEPARTMENT SERVICE

- **Teaching:** University of Michigan, Graduate Student Instructor, Economics 101 (2024–2026); Pontifical Catholic University of Peru, Teaching Assistant, Macroeconomics (2018).
- **Department Service:** Development Lunch Co-Organizer (2025–2026); Ph.D. Admissions Committee (2026).

TECHNICAL SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

- **Technical skills: Software, programming & visualization:** Python, R, Stata, Tableau, Julia, MATLAB, SPSS, Xpress-Mosel, LaTeX, HTML, CSS, JavaScript; **data engineering & computing:** SQL, ETL, APIs, cloud platforms (AWS), Git, Linux, Bash, high-performance computing; **machine learning & AI:** supervised learning, unsupervised learning, NLP, LLMs, agentic workflows, Model Context Protocol (MCP); **survey, experimental & geospatial tools:** GIS, SurveyCTO, Qualtrics, ODK, oTree.
- **Languages:** Spanish (native), English (professional proficiency), Chinese (basic proficiency).